

Internalized Cryptography in the McCormick Case: A Cognitive and Sociolinguistic Framework

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Author's Note (2026 Update): This paper was later expanded into my full-length forensic analysis *The McCormick Cipher*, which develops the cognitive, linguistic, and structural framework introduced here.

Abstract

The 1999 death of Ricky McCormick and his encrypted notes remain enduring forensic puzzles. This paper proposes that the notes are not conventional ciphers but examples of internalised cryptography—a personal, intuitively developed system shaped by limited literacy, cognitive divergence, and sociocultural marginalisation. Drawing on forensic linguistics, cognitive psychology, and trauma-informed analysis, the study introduces a human-centred framework for interpreting McCormick's writing as autobiographical encoding. Through phonetic reconstruction, contextual mapping, and narrative emulation, the paper reframes the notes as mnemonic artefacts rather than cryptographic failures. This approach expands the forensic toolkit for decoding anomalous texts and challenges normative assumptions about literacy, coherence, and communicative intent.

Keywords: forensic authorship analysis, deceptive writing, evidentiary linguistics, cognitive load, questioned documents, McCormick case

1. Introduction

In June 1999, the body of Ricky McCormick was discovered in a rural area of St. Charles County, Missouri. In his pockets were two sheets of paper filled with handwritten strings of symbols, abbreviations, and letter sequences that have confounded cryptologists and investigators for over two decades. Despite involvement from the Federal Bureau of Investigation's (FBI) Cryptanalysis and Racketeering Records Unit (CRRU) and the American Cryptogram Association, the notes remain unsolved.

Biographical Context and Literacy Profile

Ricky McCormick was a man with a limited formal education and a history of unemployment. His life was marked by frequent moves and a lack of stable social or family structures. Though he was known to write, his family reported his handwriting was often difficult to read, reflecting a non-standard form of literacy. Further evidence of his unique cognitive profile comes from his family, who described him as talking "like he was in another world." A psychiatrist who once evaluated him reportedly stated that he had a "brick wall in his mind" that he refused to break (Tritto, 2012). These biographical details are critical, as they form the foundation for a central argument of this paper: that McCormick's writing system was not a deliberate cipher but a cognitive adaptation born from his unique life circumstances. Traditional analytical approaches, grounded in assumptions of structured encryption and algorithmic logic, have failed to produce results (Federal Bureau of Investigation, 2011, paras. 1–2).

This paper reframes the McCormick case not merely as a cryptographic mystery, but as a failure of conventional paradigms to account for cognitive and sociolinguistic nuance. The inability of traditional cryptanalysis to decode McCormick's notes suggests a deeper misalignment between analytical tools and the lived realities of marginalized individuals.

Limitations of Conventional Cryptanalysis

To understand why conventional methods failed, we must first examine their underlying assumptions. Conventional cryptanalysis operates under the assumption that encoded messages are designed with external intelligibility in mind—that they follow logical, algorithmic structures intended for decipherment by others. This paradigm fails when applied to cognitively marginalized individuals whose writing may reflect internal logic rather than external encryption. As Coulthard and Johnson (2010) argue, forensic linguistics must account for linguistic deviance not as error, but as alternative structure. Similarly, Van der Kolk (2014) emphasizes that trauma can fragment language and memory, leading to nonlinear, sensory-driven expression.

McCormick's notes, viewed through this lens, are not cryptographic failures but artifacts of autobiographical encoding shaped by psychological and sociolinguistic realities.

To address this gap, the paper introduces the theory of **Internalized Cryptography**—a framework that interprets McCormick's notes not as encrypted messages for others, but as autobiographical encodings shaped by his cognitive profile, emotional state, and linguistic environment. This theory shifts the focus from deciphering a cipher to understanding a person.

Conceptual Pillars of Internalized Cryptography

The framework is built on five conceptual pillars: Unintentional Encryption, Phonetic Symbol System, Cognitive Camouflage, Embodied Cipher, and Encoding Through Unliteracy.

Interpretive Strategies for Empathetic Decryption

These pillars are operationalized through five interpretive strategies: Psychological Profiling, Phonetic Deconstruction, Contextual Mapping, Oral Reconstruction, and Narrative Emulation. Together, these tools offer a human-centric lens for decoding anomalous texts. Rather than treating McCormick's notes as cryptographic failures, this approach views them as successful expressions of a deeply personal logic—rendered opaque only by the assumption that literacy must conform to normative conventions.

(P1)

(MND H V NE A R SE - J - S M K N A R E) (P1 S M D)

TFRNE N P I N SE N P B S E R C B R N S E N P R S E I N C
 P R S E N M B S E O P R E H L D W L D N C B E (T F X L F T X L N C B E)
 A L - P R P P I T X L Y P P I Y N C B E M G K S E W L D R C B R N S E P R S E
 W L D R C B R N S E N T O G N E N T X S E - C B S L E - C I T R S E W L D N C B E
 A L W L D N C B E T S M E L S E R L S E V R G L S N E A S N W L D N C B E
 (N O P R S E N L S R E N C B E) N T E G D D M N S E N C U R E R C O R N E
 (T E N E T F R N E N C B R T S E N C B E I N G)
 (F I R S E P R S E O N D E 7) N C B E
 (C O N S E P R S E O N S B E 74 N C B E)
 (P R T S E P R S E O N R E D E 75 N C B E)
 (T F J A C H S P S O L E M P D E L U S E T O T E W L D N W L D N C B E)
 (194 W L D ' S N C B E) (T R F X L)

Figure 1 *The Primary Note Recovered from Ricky McCormick*

Note. The dense pattern of letters, numbers, dashes, and parenthetical groupings characterizes the text as an anomalous cipher. This sheet contains the core sequences—including "WLDNXPN" and phrases using "NCBE"—that were the primary focus of the Phonetic Deconstruction analysis. Reprinted with permission from the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI), U.S. Department of Justice.

NOTES

ALPTE GLSE - SE ERTE
 VLSE MTSE-CTSE-USE-FRTSE
 PNRTRSE ONDRSE WLD NCBE
 N WLD XLRCMSP NEWLD STS MEYL
 DULMT 6TUNSE NCBEYC

(MUNSAISTEN MU NARSE)
 KLSE-LRSTE-TRSE-TISE-MKSE N-MKSE
 (SAEUNSE SE N-MKSE)
 NMNLCBKNSE PTE 2ATEWSRCKKSE
 36 MLSE 74 SPRKSE 29KENO8OLE 173RTKSE
 356LE CLGSE UNUTKE DKRSE PSESHLE
 651 MTLSE HTLSE NCUTCTRS NMRE
 99.845 2UNEPLSE NCSEADLTSE 2SRSENB SE
 NSEKQNSE PUTSE WLD NCBE (3XBL)
 NMNSE NRSE INRNTLRCEBANGS UTSAKONE
 LSPNSE NGSPSE MKSE K8SE 2CBE ANU XL'R
 HM CSE NMREPCBE 1/2 MUNDPLSE
 D-W-M-Y MFL XDLX

Figure 2 *The Secondary Note from the McCormick Case*

Note. The secondary note recovered with the victim, used to establish the context of Narrative Emulation and Contextual Mapping through its numeric sequences and date markers. Reprinted with permission from the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI), U.S. Department of Justice.

This paper contends that the enduring interpretive impasse stems from a misalignment between existing decoding methodologies and the true nature of McCormick's writing. Specifically, it argues that the notes may not constitute deliberate encryption but rather represent an unintentional cipher: a personalized communicative system shaped by McCormick's limited formal literacy, regional dialect, psychological state, and mnemonic adaptations. These elements may have converged into a functional, inward-facing mode of expression—intended not to conceal information from others, but to encode memory and intent for himself.

The proposed framework offers a new lens through which to interpret McCormick's notes—and potentially other anomalous texts produced outside standard educational and linguistic systems. Drawing on cognitive profiling, phonetic reconstruction, and sociolinguistic analysis, this study

introduces a methodology for approaching unconventional communicative artifacts that fall outside traditional decryptive paradigms. It explores the possibility that McCormick's notes are not cryptographic puzzles, but reflections of internalized linguistic systems shaped by psychological adversity and cognitive adaptation.

2. Theoretical Framework: McCormick Logic

The following section proposes that the perceived encryption in McCormick's notes may be an emergent byproduct of atypical cognitive and linguistic systems rather than a deliberate cryptographic structure. This framework, depicted in **Figure 3**, is supported by five conceptual pillars:

The Empathetic Decryption Framework for Internalized Cryptography

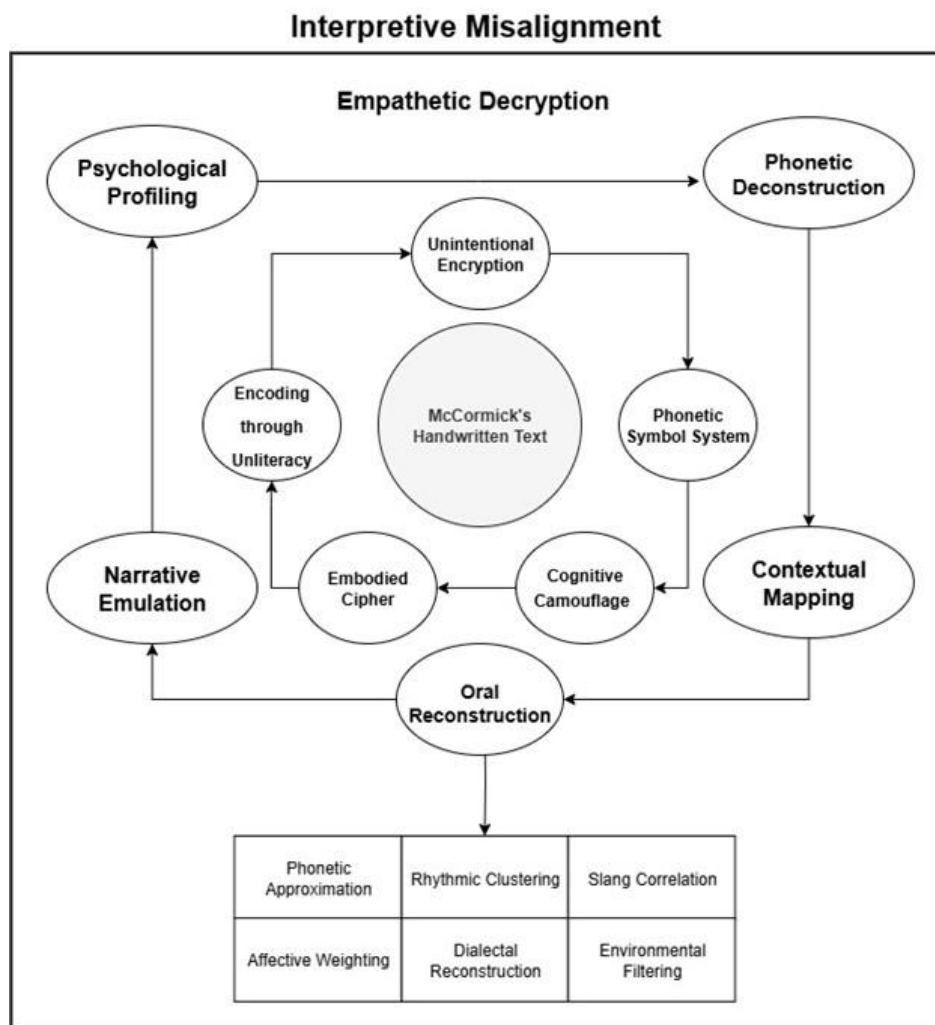


Figure 3 The Empathetic Decryption Framework for Internalized Cryptography

Unintentional Encryption

McCormick's notes may not reflect a conscious intent to conceal information through formal encryption. Instead, the observed opacity could be the result of idiosyncratic linguistic encoding shaped by nonstandard literacy, psychological coping mechanisms, and private mnemonic devices. This paper proposes that what appears to external observers as a cipher may, in fact, be a personally coherent system of notation comprehensible only to its author.

Unintentional Encryption refers to the spontaneous development of opaque communicative systems that are internally coherent but externally indecipherable. These systems often emerge in individuals with limited formal literacy, cognitive divergence, or socially marginalized backgrounds. For example, people with nonstandard literacy may encode meaning through phonetic spellings, symbolic repetition, or fragmented syntax—not to conceal information, but to preserve it in a form accessible to themselves. Such encoding reflects a personalized logic shaped by lived experience and adaptive strategies for memory and communication. In McCormick's case, the notes may represent a mnemonic system designed for internal recall rather than external interpretation.

Phonetic Symbol System

Preliminary analyses suggest that McCormick's strings of letters may correspond to phonemic approximations rather than orthographic representations. This approach, common among individuals with limited access to formal education or affected by certain learning disorders, prioritizes how language sounds over how it is conventionally written. Thus, the same sequence may represent different semantic values depending on context, inflection, or emotional state, akin to glossolalia or idiolect (Crystal, 1997, pp. 112–118).

A representative example of phonetic substitution can be seen in the string “WLDNXP,” which may phonetically approximate “wildin’ ex on.” This interpretation relies on auditory plausibility rather than orthographic convention, suggesting that McCormick encoded speech sounds rather than written words. Such substitutions are common among individuals with limited formal literacy, where spelling reflects phonemic awareness rather than standardized rules. As Crystal (1997) notes, phonetic spellings often emerge in idiolects shaped by oral tradition, and their semantic value depends heavily on context and vocal inflection. In McCormick's case, phonetic substitution may have served as a mnemonic device, allowing him to preserve meaning through sound-based encoding intelligible primarily to himself.

Cognitive Camouflage through Apparent Illiteracy

McCormick's perceived illiteracy may have inadvertently shielded the notes from scrutiny. Drawing on Coulthard and Johnson's discussion of linguistic deviance and interpretive bias, one might argue that texts deviating from standard norms are often dismissed as meaningless. In this case, marginalization produced concealment—not through encryption, but through societal disregard (Coulthard & Johnson, 2010, pp. 113–117).

A well-documented example of interpretive bias against nonstandard literacy is found in judicial contexts where speakers of African American Vernacular English (AAVE) are misheard or misunderstood due to dialectal differences. Rickford and King (2016) describe how jurors and

legal professionals often fail to comprehend AAVE speech patterns, leading to misinterpretation of testimony and diminished credibility of speakers. This bias reflects a broader sociolinguistic issue: the assumption that linguistic deviation from standardized norms signals incoherence or lack of intelligence. Angermeyer (2022) expands on this by showing how institutional translation practices can reinforce stereotypes and restrict participation for speakers of subordinated dialects, a phenomenon he terms “punitive multilingualism.” These examples illustrate how nonstandard literacy and dialects are not merely overlooked but actively marginalized in institutional settings, reinforcing systemic inequality.

Embodied Cipher

Rather than encoding standard linguistic content, the notes may serve as external supports for memory—anchoring routines, spatial cues, and personal associations. Drawing on Norman’s exploration of cognitive artifacts, these elements operate not as messages to be read by others but as tools designed to scaffold McCormick’s own cognition and daily function. In this view, decoding the notes would require reconstructing not a language system, but McCormick’s cognitive experience and internal logic (Norman, 1993, pp. 43–47).

Embodied cognition refers to the idea that cognitive processes are deeply rooted in the body’s interactions with the world, including sensorimotor experiences and environmental context. In forensic and clinical settings, this concept is exemplified by the use of external memory aids—such as notes, drawings, or spatial arrangements—to scaffold cognition. Norman (1993) describes these as “cognitive artifacts,” tools that extend mental function into the physical environment. For instance, individuals with memory impairments may rely on written cues or object placement to navigate daily routines, not as communicative acts but as embodied supports for internal logic. In McCormick’s case, the notes may have served a similar function: not as messages to others, but as spatial and symbolic anchors for his own cognitive processes.

Encoding through Unliteracy

This theory posits that McCormick may have operated within a framework of what could be termed functional illiteracy, wherein communicative capacity emerges not from formal instruction but from situated, culturally embedded practices. Drawing on Heath’s ethnographic work and Scribner and Cole’s analysis of non-school literacies, such systems reflect localized, experiential knowledge rather than transferable linguistic conventions.

These self-generated, highly contextualized forms of expression may be opaque to external observers yet fully coherent within the subject’s internal narrative architecture (Heath, 1983, pp. 347–349; Scribner & Cole, 1981, pp. 236–238). Heath’s (1983) ethnographic study *Ways with Words* documents how children and adults in two working-class communities developed literacy practices rooted in oral tradition, local routines, and community-specific norms. These practices, while effective within their cultural context, were often misinterpreted by educators and outsiders as signs of illiteracy or cognitive deficiency.

Similarly, Scribner and Cole (1981) argue that literacy must be understood as a set of culturally situated activities, not merely as the ability to read and write according to formal standards. In McCormick’s case, his writing may reflect such functional literacy—opaque to conventional analysis but coherent within his lived experience. For instance, McCormick’s use of symbolic

repetition and phonetic spellings parallels the kind of mnemonic scaffolding observed in Heath's study, suggesting a personalized system of meaning-making.

Marginalized individuals may instinctively develop writing styles that obscure meaning—not out of cryptographic intent, but as a form of psychological and social defence. This phenomenon, termed **adaptive obfuscation**—a self-protective strategy where linguistic irregularity shields meaning from external scrutiny—reflects how complexity can serve as a barrier against misinterpretation or exploitation.

As Coulthard and Johnson (2010) argue, linguistic deviance is often misinterpreted as incoherence, when it may in fact be a deliberate form of concealment shaped by social context. Similarly, Van der Kolk (2014) describes how trauma can lead to fragmented, nonlinear expression, which may appear cryptic but is internally coherent to the author. Markowitz and Hancock (2016) provide empirical evidence that deceptive writing—such as fraudulent scientific papers—exhibits higher levels of linguistic obfuscation, including reduced readability and increased jargon, suggesting that complexity can be strategically constructed to mask intent.

In sociolinguistic contexts, Baker-Bell (2020) and Kroskrity (2021) highlight how speakers of marginalized dialects, such as Black Language (BL), often face linguistic discrimination that pressures them to conform to dominant norms. This pressure can lead to intentional complexity or code-switching as a form of survival and resistance.

In McCormick's case, the use of phonetic spellings, erratic structure, and symbolic repetition may have served not only as mnemonic scaffolding but also to control interpretation—ensuring that only he could access the full meaning of his notes. This reframes apparent illiteracy not as deficiency, but as linguistic agency—where complexity is constructed not to deceive, but to protect.

3. Methodology: Empathetic Decryption Approach

Having established the conceptual pillars of internalised cryptography, we now turn to the interpretive strategies that operationalise this framework. This section outlines a heuristic for interpreting nontraditional symbolic writing by individuals whose literacy practices fall outside standardized norms. Termed **empathetic decryption**, the approach (as illustrated in Figure 3) emphasizes cognitive alignment with the writer's lived experience rather than applying rigid cryptanalytic systems. It is grounded in five interpretive strategies:

Psychological Profiling

Understanding the writer's cognitive profile is foundational. McCormick's notes are situated within a framework that acknowledges psychological impact of adversity and life stressors on memory, including somatic encoding, implicit recall, and adaptive linguistic behaviour. As Levine (2015) notes, autobiographical memory under stress may be preserved nonverbally and retrieved through sensory associations rather than linear language (pp. 43–47). Personal history, social context, and behavioural patterns offer critical insight into the construction of internally generated notation systems.

A compelling example of psychological profiling in forensic linguistics is found in the analysis of the Unabomber case, where linguistic patterns were used to infer cognitive and behavioural traits. Fitzgerald and Shuy identified orthographic anomalies, dated idioms, and syntactic rigidity that reflected Ted Kaczynski's psychological isolation and ideological fixation (Crowder, 2024; Pedroncelli, 2023). These linguistic fingerprints were not merely stylistic—they revealed a cognitive architecture shaped by paranoia, intellectual elitism, and obsessive control. Similarly, Busch and McNamara (2020) argue that trauma-informed linguistic analysis can uncover how psychological adversity shapes expression. In trauma-affected individuals, language may become fragmented, nonlinear, and emotionally weighted—features often misread as incoherence. Their work supports the use of discourse analysis to reconstruct psychological states from linguistic artifacts, especially in cases where conventional syntax fails to capture lived experience.

Psychological profiling must account for McCormick's reported cognitive divergence, social isolation, and the psychiatrist's remark—quoted by his family—that he had a 'brick wall in his mind' (Tritto, 2012). His notes may reflect somatic encoding and implicit memory—preserved through sensory associations rather than linear narrative. This aligns with Levine's (2015) observation that autobiographical memory under stress often bypasses verbal logic, instead surfacing through symbolic and rhythmic cues.

Phonetic Deconstruction

Although McCormick's personal history does not include verified trauma, this analysis remains sensitive to how social and cognitive marginalization may influence linguistic form. Drawing from trauma-aware frameworks, it considers how expressive irregularities might emerge from lived experience rather than deception or disorder. This strategy, rooted in oral tradition and phonetic reconstruction, interprets McCormick's writing as a sound-based system shaped by lived speech rather than formal literacy. Rather than relying on syntactic norms, each symbol cluster is vocalized in multiple permutations, privileging auditory plausibility over orthographic convention. This paper proposes the following speculative interpretations as heuristic examples of how trauma-aware encoding might manifest. For example, "PUNYEN SEVERNEI" may phonetically encode "puny and severing," reflecting McCormick's perception of physical weakness and emotional rupture. Similarly, "PNEPNTWETEPNEP" could represent "pain went away," functioning as a deeply personal lament.

These examples illustrate how phonetic reconstruction intersects with emotional encoding and trauma-aware interpretation. This approach aligns with research on nonstandard literacy, wherein phonetic transcription compensates for the absence of conventional spelling and reflects community-developed practices formed without formal instruction (Heath, 1983, pp. 205–209). In forensic authorship analysis, phonetic spellings—such as "nife" for *knife* or "ded" for *dead*—are often dismissed as signs of illiteracy. However, forensic linguists have shown that such spellings may reflect consistent phonemic patterns tied to regional dialects and speech habits. These features, when cross-referenced with known audio samples, can support authorship attribution.

Grant (2022) emphasizes that linguistic features rooted in dialect and context—especially in cases involving nonstandard literacy—can serve as reliable indicators of identity when

interpreted through a sociolinguistic lens. His work underscores the importance of analysing linguistic variation not as error, but as meaningful structure within forensic contexts.

Contextual Mapping

Decoded elements are cross-referenced with familiar people, locations, routines, or vocabulary from McCormick’s environment. This grounds interpretation in contextual reality, allowing analysts to identify embedded memory cues or emotional referents. As Scribner and Cole argue, functional literacy is culturally situated; meaning emerges not from abstract decoding, but from the alignment between symbols and lived experience (Scribner & Cole, 1981, pp. 236–238). Contextual mapping plays a critical role in forensic interpretation, especially when analysts must align symbolic or linguistic artifacts with the subject’s lived environment. In forensic mental health assessments (FMHAs), evaluators are increasingly urged to incorporate cultural and contextual factors—such as racial identity, community norms, and experiences of discrimination—into their evaluations. Fanniff, York, and Gutierrez (2023) conducted a consensus study with board-certified forensic psychologists and dual experts in cultural competence, identifying 28 practices deemed essential for culturally informed assessments. These included mapping examinees’ self-identified racial and ethnic backgrounds, acculturation experiences, and exposure to systemic oppression—all of which shape how individuals express themselves under legal scrutiny.

In McCormick’s case, contextual mapping may involve cross-referencing decoded symbols with known people, places, and routines from his life. This approach reframes interpretation not as abstract decryption, but as a reconstruction of meaning grounded in personal geography and sociocultural experience.

Oral Reconstruction

Here, the notes are approached less as written records and more as echoes of internalized speech. The goal is to perceive rhythm, cadence, and sonic architecture beneath the symbols—assuming McCormick was transcribing subvocalized speech or abstracted auditory sequences known only to him. To strengthen this strategy, future work will seek voice samples or speech-related data to reconstruct McCormick’s vocal register. Dialectal reconstruction, slang correlation, and affective weighting will be used to simulate his oral logic.

This dimension is crucial: it acknowledges that marginalized cognition isn’t just reactive—it can be strategically expressive.

To implement this, the following procedural steps are proposed:

1. **Phonetic Approximation**
Sound out letter groupings aloud without correcting spelling. Read as written, preserving possible mispronunciations.
2. **Rhythmic Clustering**
Identify recurring beats, cadences, or structures suggesting oral patterning—such as slogans, chants, street slang, or lyrical phrases.
3. **Slang Correlation**
Cross-reference outputs with regional slang or idiolects relevant to McCormick’s community.

4. Affective Weighting

Mark sequences with emotional cadence (e.g., abrupt shifts, staccato rhythms), as they may signify memory triggers or personal meaning.

5. Dialectal Reconstruction

Interpret symbols through McCormick's likely vocal register, including regional dialects or speech irregularities. Intonation may be key to resolving ambiguity.

Trauma-informed oral reconstruction emphasizes the importance of rhythm, cadence, and emotional resonance in interpreting idiosyncratic writing. The Voice of Witness project outlines ten key practices for trauma-informed storytelling, including non-judgmental listening, sensitivity to triggers, and cultural humility. These principles guide oral history practitioners in reconstructing narratives that may be fragmented or nonlinear due to trauma. Rather than imposing syntactic expectations, analysts are encouraged to perceive the speaker's internal logic through vocal patterns, emotional cadence, and contextual cues (Voice of Witness, 2024, pp. 3–9).

In forensic contexts, this approach aligns with the work of Tammy Gales and Tim Grant, who emphasize the role of spoken linguistic practices in legal interpretation. Their research highlights how short-form messages—such as texts or notes—can reflect oral logic, especially when produced by individuals with limited formal literacy or under psychological stress. Oral reconstruction, in this sense, becomes a method of decoding not just language, but lived experience (Cambridge University Press, 2024).

In McCormick's case, oral reconstruction may involve simulating his speech rhythm, dialectal features, and emotional tone to interpret symbolic sequences. This method reframes the notes not as cryptographic puzzles, but as echoes of internalized speech—shaped by oral tradition, survival strategies, and possible psychological stress.

6. Environmental Filtering

While phonetic reconstruction foregrounds the auditory logic of McCormick's writing, a complementary lens emerges when considering how his symbolic choices may also reflect environmental stimuli and perceptual filtering. This shift from sound to setting invites a broader understanding of how context shapes expression. Overlay decoded phonetic segments onto McCormick's known life details—associating phrases with people, events, or routines to support interpretive hypotheses.

This process functions less as forensic decryption and more as *oral ethnography*—a reconstruction of narrative from structurally opaque linguistic remnants.

Narrative Emulation

This final component models McCormick's internal logic under cognitively altered cognitive conditions. Instead of assuming syntactic continuity or linear order, it simulates a storytelling process shaped by somatic memory, emotional rhythm, and associative reasoning. As Van der Kolk (2014) notes, psychological adversities can fragment autobiographical memories and disrupt narrative structures, leading to nonlinear, sensory-driven expression (Van der Kolk, 2014, pp. 236–241).

Narrative emulation involves reconstructing fragmented or nonlinear storytelling patterns that may emerge from cognitively disrupted or emotionally burdened states. In trauma-focused cognitive behavioural therapy (TF-CBT), practitioners use structured trauma narration to help youth process distressing memories. These narratives often begin as disjointed or symbolic

expressions, requiring therapists to guide the child in gradually assembling a coherent story through open-ended prompts, emotional scaffolding, and visual structuring (Gallo, 2019, pp. 3–7).

The **Voice of Witness** framework also supports narrative emulation by emphasizing non-judgmental listening, cultural humility, and emotional pacing. Their trauma-informed storytelling practices encourage narrators to lead the structure of their own stories, allowing for nonlinear, emotionally weighted, and symbolic expression. This approach validates fragmented narratives as authentic reflections of lived experience, rather than deviations from normative syntax (Voice of Witness, 2024, pp. 2–6).

In McCormick’s case, narrative emulation may involve simulating how he might have constructed meaning under psychological stress—using symbolic repetition, phonetic scaffolding, and associative logic. Rather than imposing linear coherence, this method seeks to reconstruct the emotional and cognitive rhythm embedded in his writing.

Methodological Elevation

These five strategies—psychological profiling, phonetic deconstruction, contextual mapping, oral reconstruction, and narrative emulation—form a formal methodology. They operate in tandem to decode texts that defy conventional analysis.

Each decoded line serves as a mini proof-of-concept, demonstrating how lived encryption—structured by memory, survival, and possible psychological stress—can be deciphered through empathetic tools.

McCormick didn’t need formal cryptographic training. He had lived encryption—the kind that comes from knowing how to speak without being overheard. This methodology is not just theoretical. It offers a new tool for decoding anomalous texts, which could be formally proposed to investigative bodies, including the FBI. It reframes cryptanalysis as a human-centred act of listening, not just solving. To strengthen the oral reconstruction strategy, future research should prioritize sourcing McCormick’s personal linguistic artifacts—such as letters, notes to family, signatures, or recorded speech. These materials would allow for comparative sociolinguistic analysis, enabling researchers to identify consistent phonetic patterns, idiolectal markers, and emotional cadence across contexts. As outlined by the UK Parliamentary Office of Science and Technology (2015), forensic linguistics and phonetics routinely support authorship analysis and speaker profiling by comparing disputed texts or speech samples with known exemplars to assess linguistic similarity and distinctiveness.

Additionally, trauma-informed linguistic profiling offers tools for interpreting fragmented or emotionally weighted language. Busch and McNamara (2020) argue that linguistic analysis can illuminate how trauma shapes expression, particularly in contexts where conventional syntax fails to capture lived experience. Their work supports the use of discourse analysis to reconstruct psychological states from language artifacts.

Contemporary sociolinguistic research also highlights the value of personal writing samples—especially letters and diaries—as sources of “language of immediacy,” which closely reflect spoken language and emotional authenticity. Elspaß (2012) emphasizes that such texts, often

produced by individuals with limited formal literacy, provide insight into natural linguistic variation and autobiographical encoding.

By examining McCormick’s known writing and speech, analysts could reconstruct his phonetic logic and oral rhythm, providing a “Rosetta Stone” for decoding his notes. The integration of forensic phonetics, trauma-informed discourse analysis, and sociolinguistic comparison would elevate the empathetic decryption model from theory to investigative practice.

Illustrative Example

To demonstrate the framework in action, we now turn to a practical decoding attempt. A string such as “NCBE WLDNXPXN 20XRMN” may initially appear indecipherable. Yet, when read phonetically and rhythmically, one might interpret it as: *“I seen B[rian] wildin’—ex on Main.”* Such insights arise not from lexical decoding, but from reconstructing plausible narrative fragments rooted in oral speech and lived cognition.

Comparative Analysis: Idiosyncratic Writing in Forensic Contexts

The interpretive challenges posed by Ricky McCormick’s notes are not isolated. Forensic linguistics has long grappled with texts that defy conventional syntax, orthography, and communicative norms—often because they emerge from deeply personal, idiosyncratic systems of expression. Comparative cases illustrate how such writing, initially dismissed as incoherent or deceptive, can yield profound insights when approached through empathetic and context-sensitive methodologies.

The Unabomber Case: Linguistic Fingerprints and Authorial Idiosyncrasy

The case of Ted Kaczynski, known as the Unabomber, is a landmark in forensic linguistics. His 35,000-word manifesto was pivotal in his identification—not through cryptographic analysis, but via linguistic profiling. Forensic linguists James Fitzgerald and Roger Shuy identified unique orthographic choices (e.g., “clew” for “clue,” “wilfully” for “willfully”), dated idioms, and syntactic structures that matched Kaczynski’s personal writings. These features were not part of a deliberate code but reflected a consistent, idiosyncratic linguistic fingerprint (Fitzgerald & Shuy, as cited in Crowder, 2024; Pedroncelli, 2023).

The Darnell Rusan Case: Coerced Confessions and Linguistic Misattribution

In the case of Darnell Rusan, forensic linguists examined a series of confessions that bore linguistic features inconsistent with Rusan’s known speech patterns. The confessions were found to be heavily guided by police interrogation, raising concerns about authorship and coercion. Linguistic incongruence between Rusan’s idiolect and the confession text revealed how institutional bias and interpretive rigidity can distort forensic outcomes (Hurt, 2025).

Autobiographical Encoding in Forensic Reports

Recent research by London, Kulkofsky, and Perez (2021) explores how autobiographical memory and suggestibility shape forensic narratives, particularly in vulnerable populations. Their review of children’s forensic reports reveals that fragmented, nonlinear, and sensory-driven recollections—features that mirror McCormick’s note structure—are common in trauma-affected individuals. These findings support the notion that nonstandard expression may be a function of cognitive and emotional encoding, not deception or incoherence.

Implications for McCormick's Case

These comparative cases validate the core premise of Internalized Cryptography: that idiosyncratic writing can be a coherent, autobiographical system intelligible only through contextual and empathetic analysis. They also reinforce the need for forensic methodologies that prioritize cognitive alignment over algorithmic decryption. These cases underscore the broader implications of misreading idiosyncratic texts and set the stage for a critical discussion of interpretive bias.

4. Discussion: The Void of Misinterpretation

The enduring indecipherability of McCormick's notes may stem less from their complexity than from a fundamental misapprehension of their nature. This *interpretive misalignment* is a central concept of the framework presented here (**Figure 3**). Conventional cryptographic frameworks presuppose the intentional design of encoded systems—constructed to obfuscate meaning through logic-based concealment. In contrast, the theory presented here suggests that McCormick's notes may have held meaning only within his own embodied cognitive and linguistic architecture.

This raises a critical epistemological concern: **false opacity**—the notion that an artifact appears unreadable not because it lacks meaning, but because the interpreter lacks the conceptual framework to perceive it. In McCormick's case, investigators may have applied analytical tools suited for computational problems to a document that was autobiographical in nature.

Moreover, the social context in which McCormick lived may have contributed to the systematic dismissal of his communication. Individuals with limited access to formal education are disproportionately subjected to credibility gaps in institutional interpretation (Fricker, 2007, pp. 147–152). Such disparities can lead not only to the erasure of voice, but to the categorization of private language as incoherent or pathological—when it may, in fact, reflect adaptive linguistic ingenuity.

This interpretive failure reflects what Fricker (2007) terms **hermeneutical injustice**—a structural gap in collective interpretive resources that renders certain experiences unintelligible. Bufkin (2024) expands this concept by arguing that victims often possess **phenomenal concepts**—subjective, experience-based understandings—that remain unrecognized due to dominant epistemic norms. This mismatch between internal coherence and external intelligibility exemplifies the kind of interpretive bias that may have obscured the meaning of McCormick's notes.

Reframing Expertise Through Empathy

Rather than imposing cryptographic models prematurely, this paper adopts an investigative stance—one that seeks to understand the cognitive and contextual background before selecting interpretive tools. The persistent inability to decode McCormick's notes reflects not the complexity of the artifact, but a misalignment between analytical methodology and the cognitive-linguistic realities of the author. Experts approached the writing with assumptions rooted in formal encryption theory—tools designed for structured, externally intelligible systems—while overlooking the possibility of internally generated, autobiographical encoding. The presumption that McCormick possessed knowledge of cryptographic systems was not only

unsubstantiated, but indicative of a broader epistemological error: the conflation of obscurity with intentional concealment. In truth, the artifact may have been legible—just not to the lens that was looking. This methodological incongruity underscores the need for empathetic decryption, a framework that begins not with algorithms but with humility. Meaning, especially within marginalized communicative forms, often resides in unfamiliar structures. Recognizing this invites a shift toward human-centred forensic analysis—one that seeks coherence not through standardization, but through reconstruction of lived experience. This interpretive failure reflects what Fricker (2007) terms **epistemic injustice**—a structural gap in collective interpretive resources that renders certain experiences unintelligible. Bufkin (2024) expands this concept by arguing that victims often possess **phenomenal concepts**—subjective, experience-based understandings—that remain unrecognized due to dominant epistemic norms. This mismatch between internal coherence and external intelligibility exemplifies the kind of **interpretive bias** that may have obscured the meaning of McCormick’s notes.

Implications for Investigative Practice

This reframing has broader implications for investigative methodology. If unconventional or idiosyncratic communicative artifacts are misclassified as “unsolvable” due to methodological rigidity, critical evidentiary leads may be overlooked. A more expansive interpretive toolkit—one that integrates linguistics, cognitive psychology, and ethnography—may be essential in such cases. As Jackendoff (2002) argues, meaning arises not solely from syntactic structure but from the interplay between conceptual representations and interface systems that link language to embodied cognition. Interpretation depends not just on rules, but on how linguistic input maps onto experience-shaped mental models (pp. 314–319).

Viewed through this lens, McCormick’s notes need not be seen as cryptographic failures, but rather as successful expressions of a deeply personal logic—rendered opaque only by the assumption that literacy must conform to normative conventions.

5. Conclusion

This paper proposes that the enduring mystery of the notes found on Ricky McCormick may stem not from sophisticated encryption, but from a fundamental misreading of their form and intent. Rather than deliberate cryptography, the notes may represent an internalized system of personal encoding—shaped by McCormick’s cognitive profile, linguistic exposure, environmental constraints, and adaptive strategies for memory and communication. The theory of Internalized Cryptography reframes forensic interpretation by shifting the analytical lens from external encryption to internal cognition. Rather than assuming that anomalous texts are designed to conceal meaning from others, this framework posits that such writing may reflect autobiographical encoding—structured by limited literacy, cognitive divergence, and sociocultural marginalization.

While there is no documented evidence that McCormick experienced trauma, research in trauma-informed linguistics offers a comparative lens for understanding how psychological adversity can shape expression. Studies have shown that fragmented, nonlinear, and emotionally weighted language—often observed in trauma-affected individuals—can resemble the structure of McCormick’s notes. These parallels are not presented as diagnostic, but as interpretive tools for understanding how marginalized cognition may manifest in writing.

This approach challenges the assumption that linguistic irregularity signals incoherence or deception. Instead, it recognizes that marginalized individuals may develop internally coherent systems of notation that defy conventional analysis. By integrating sociolinguistics, trauma-informed frameworks, and cognitive profiling, Internalized Cryptography offers a human-centred methodology for decoding texts that fall outside normative linguistic expectations.

This theory reframes the writing not as cipher text, but as autobiographical syntax: a deeply personal, experiential language intelligible only through the reconstruction of context, perception, and internal logic.

Such a reframing demands a shift in methodology. Decryption becomes an act of empathic reconstruction rather than computational analysis. It calls for listening to phonetic echoes, tracing narrative fragments, and recovering the architecture of memory embedded in unconventional form.

Ethical Dimensions of Interpretation

Misreading marginalized expression is not merely a methodological oversight—it is an ethical failure. When institutional frameworks dismiss nonstandard literacy as incoherent, they risk silencing voices that encode meaning through alternative structures. In McCormick’s case, the assumption that his notes lacked value reflects a broader societal tendency to equate deviation with deficiency. This reinforces systemic exclusion and denies individuals the dignity of being understood on their own terms. Ethical forensic practice must therefore include **cognitive empathy**, recognizing that meaning may reside in unfamiliar forms and that the act of interpretation carries moral weight. The notes must be approached not as a puzzle to be solved, but as a consciousness to be heard.

If the writing remains unreadable, it may not be because it is impenetrable—but because the lens applied to it is too narrow. McCormick’s literacy may have been unrecognizable to others, yet fully sufficient to himself.

Empathetic methodologies in forensic linguistics do more than decode—they **restore voice**. By aligning analytical tools with the lived realities of marginalized individuals, these approaches challenge the dominance of normative frameworks and open space for alternative logics. In cases like McCormick’s, empathetic decryption reframes the act of interpretation as a form of listening—one that honors complexity, context, and cognitive diversity. It is not just a method; it is a commitment to justice through understanding.

What experts failed to resolve through cryptographic models may yield to a more human tool: the willingness to accept that literacy does not always resemble our own.

To decipher McCormick is not merely to extract meaning from symbols—it is to reassemble a consciousness briefly made visible through ink.

This reading reframes McCormick not as an enigma, but as a human asserting presence through symbol.

And perhaps that is the final key:

He was not writing so others would understand him.

He was writing so he would not forget himself.

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